Install Guardian



Guardian installs in about two minutes. Pick your path below. Every step image in this guide is a drawn illustration of the flow, not a captured screenshot.

2 min	1 file	5 steps
start to finish	to download	at most

What you need

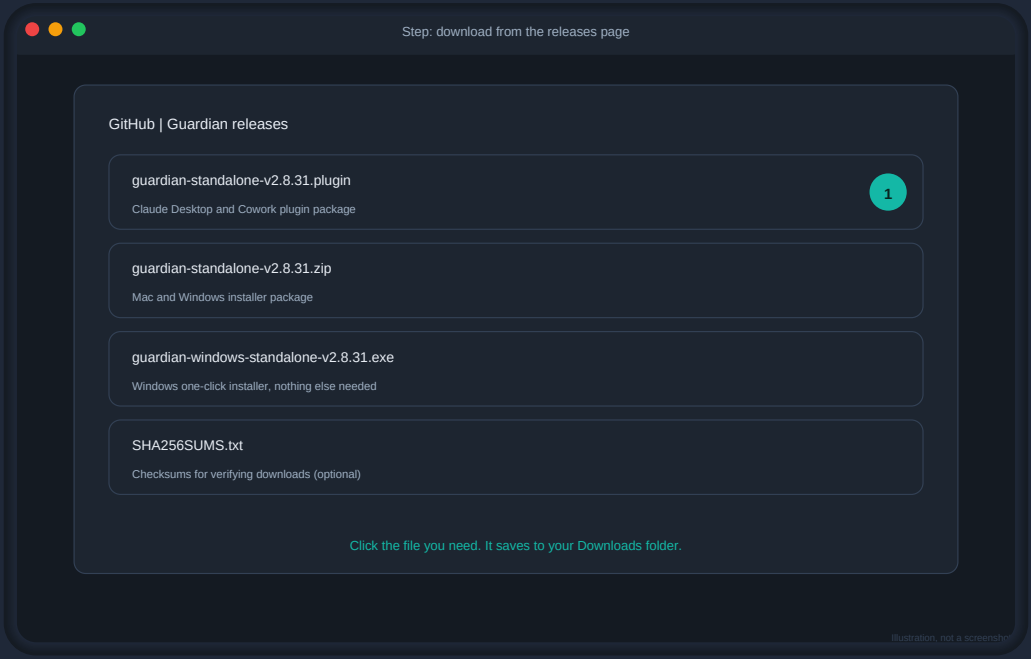
Item	Detail
An app	Claude Desktop (macOS or Windows) or claude.ai in a browser.
One file	Downloaded from the releases page in Step 1.

Item	Detail
A license key	Only for paid tiers. The free Scout tier runs without one.
Time	About two minutes, including the restart.

Pick your path

Your setup	Download this	Then follow
Claude Desktop or Cowork, Mac or Windows	the .plugin package	Step 2, plugin path
Windows with nothing else installed	the .exe installer	Step 2, Windows path
Either desktop with Node.js already installed	the .zip package	Step 2, plugin path
claude.ai in a browser	the skill folder	Steps 4 and 5

Step 1: download your file



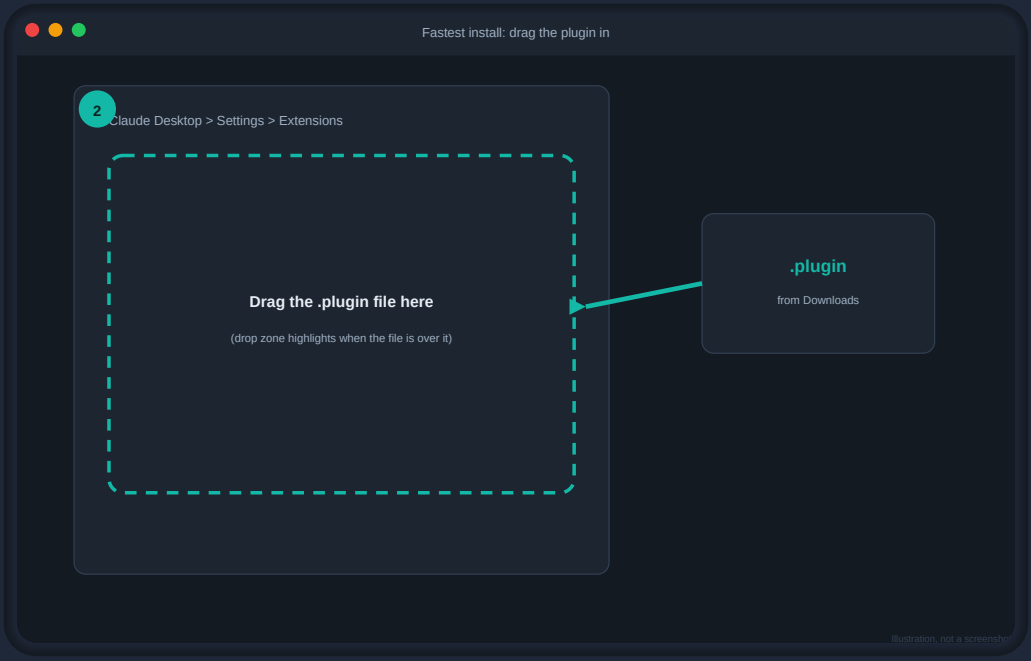
Download the file that matches your setup

Open the Guardian releases page and download the file that matches your setup:

- Claude Desktop or Cowork, Mac or Windows: `guardian-standalone-v2.8.31.plugin`
- Windows with nothing else installed: `guardian-windows-standalone-v2.8.31.exe`
- With Node.js already installed: `guardian-standalone-v2.8.31.zip`

> **Check what you downloaded.** The releases page publishes SHA256SUMS.txt next to the files. Matching checksums mean the file arrived intact. This takes ten seconds and rules out the most annoying class of install failure.

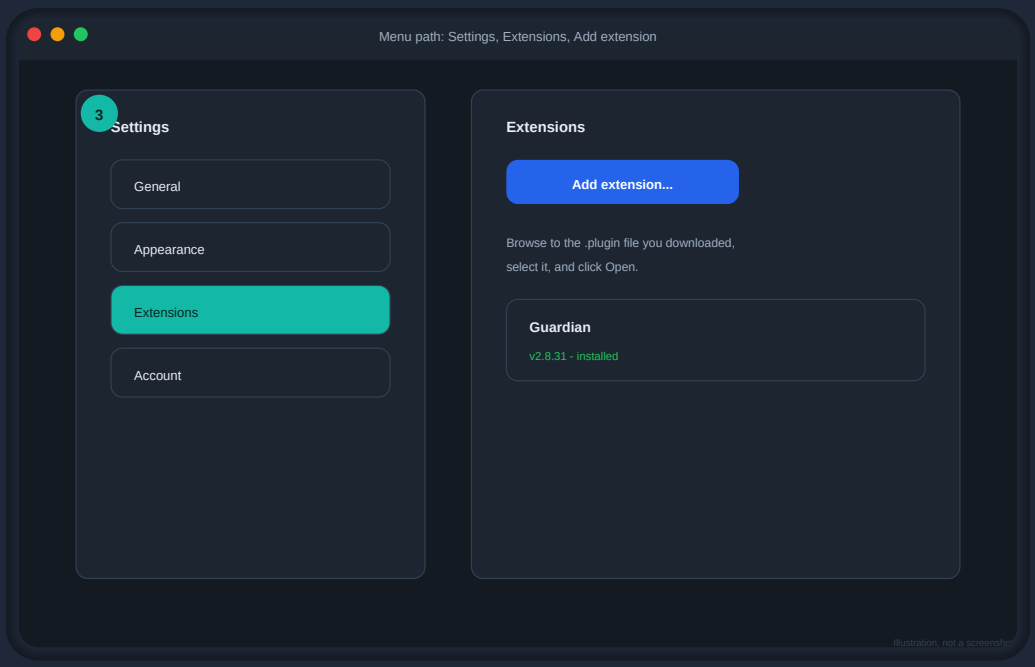
Step 2, plugin path: drag it in



Drag the plugin into Extensions

1. Open Claude Desktop.
2. Open Settings, then Extensions.
3. Drag the downloaded .plugin file into the window and drop it.

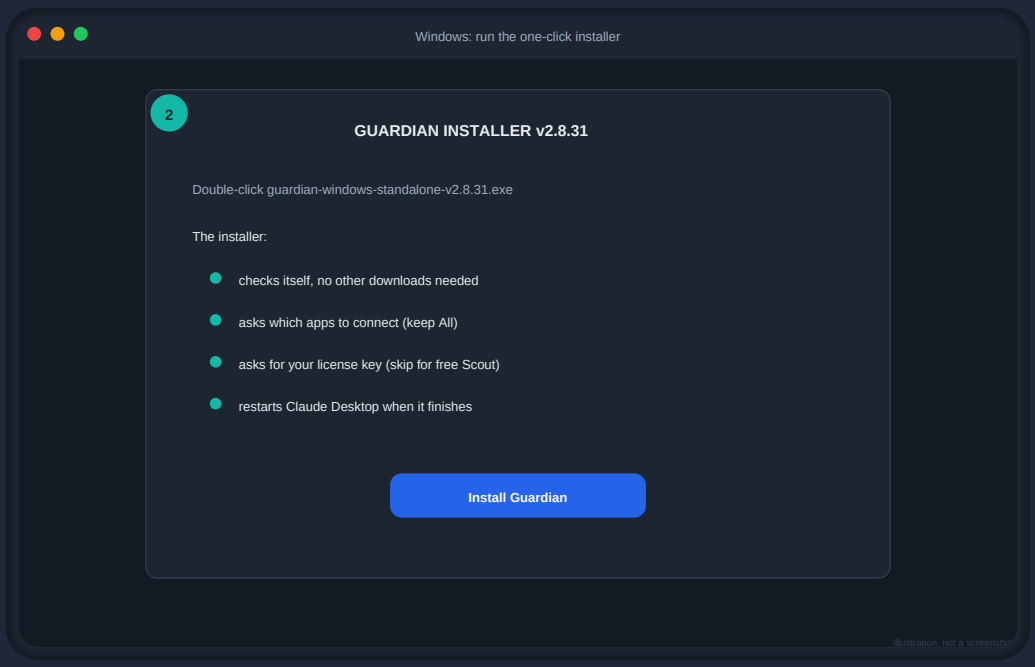
Prefer menus to dragging? The button path lands in the same place:



Settings, Extensions, Add extension

1. Open Settings, then Extensions, then Add extension.
2. Pick the .plugin file from your Downloads folder and click Open.

Step 2, Windows one-click path: run the installer

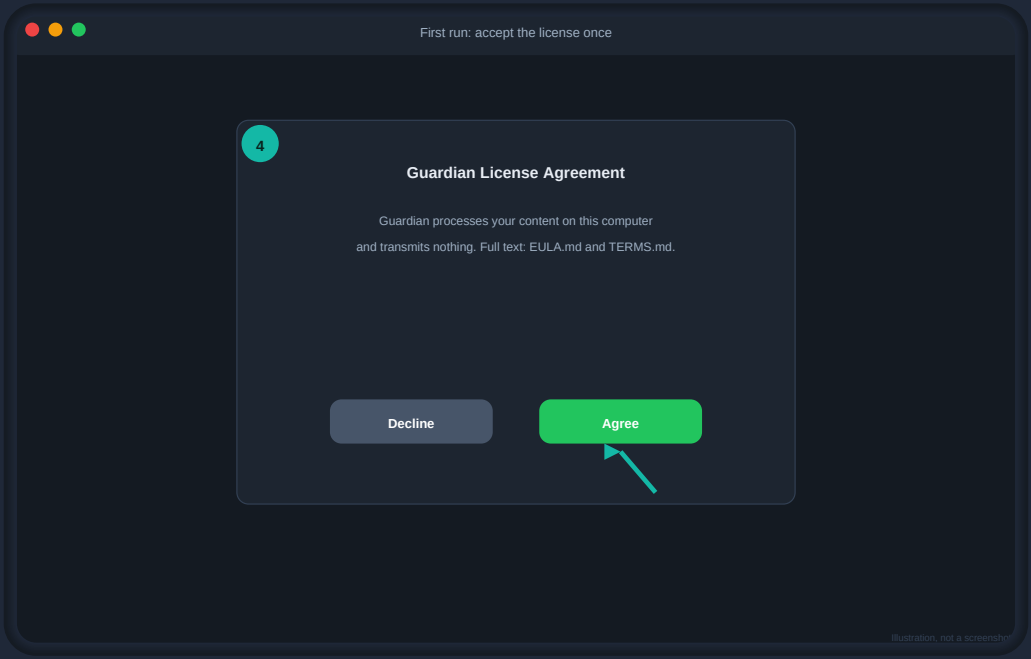


Run the Windows installer

1. Double-click the Windows installer you downloaded.
2. Keep All when it asks which apps to connect.
3. Enter your license key when asked, or skip it for the free tier.
4. Let it restart Claude Desktop when it finishes.

> **About the SmartScreen warning.** Windows sometimes flags a fresh download it has not seen before. Choose More info, then Run anyway. If company policy blocks the installer outright, use the .cmd fallback from the same releases page.

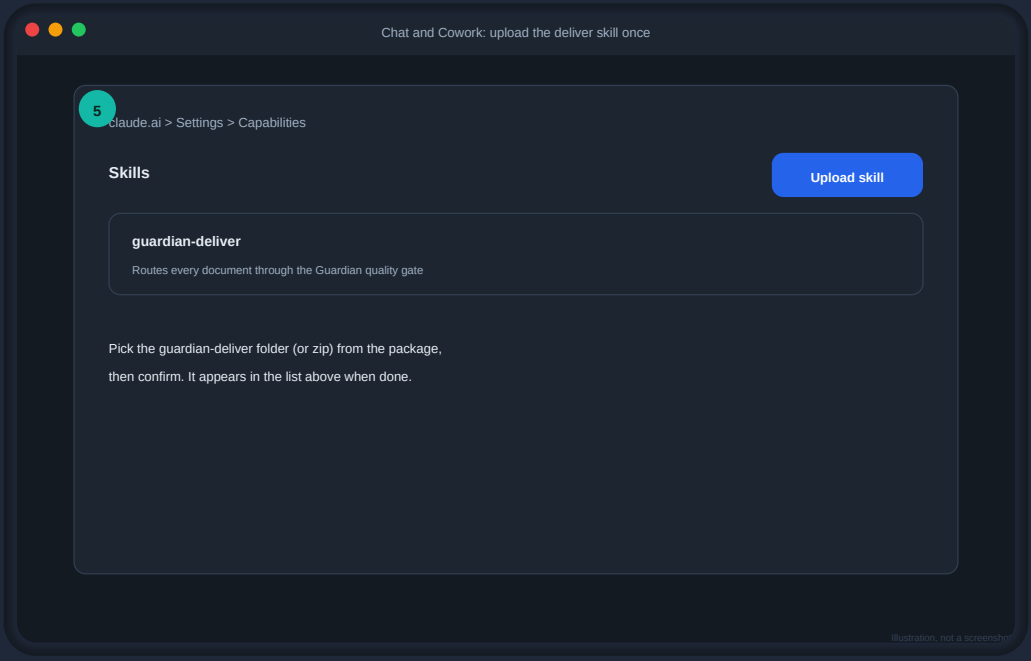
Step 3: accept the license



Accept the license once

The first run shows the license agreement once. Click Agree. Guardian stays inactive until you do, and a version update asks once more.

Step 4, Chat and Cowork on claude.ai: add the deliver skill



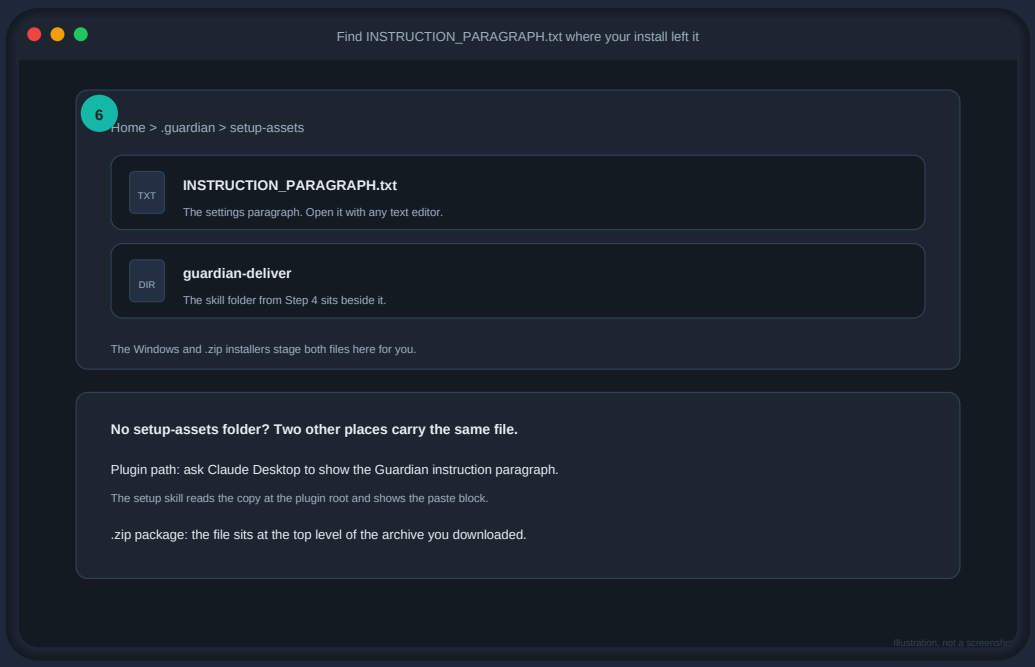
Upload the deliver skill

Desktop installs carry this skill automatically inside the plugin. For claude.ai in a browser: open Settings, then Capabilities, choose Upload skill, and pick the guardian-deliver folder from the package. One upload covers your whole account.

Step 5, Chat and Cowork on claude.ai: add the settings paragraph

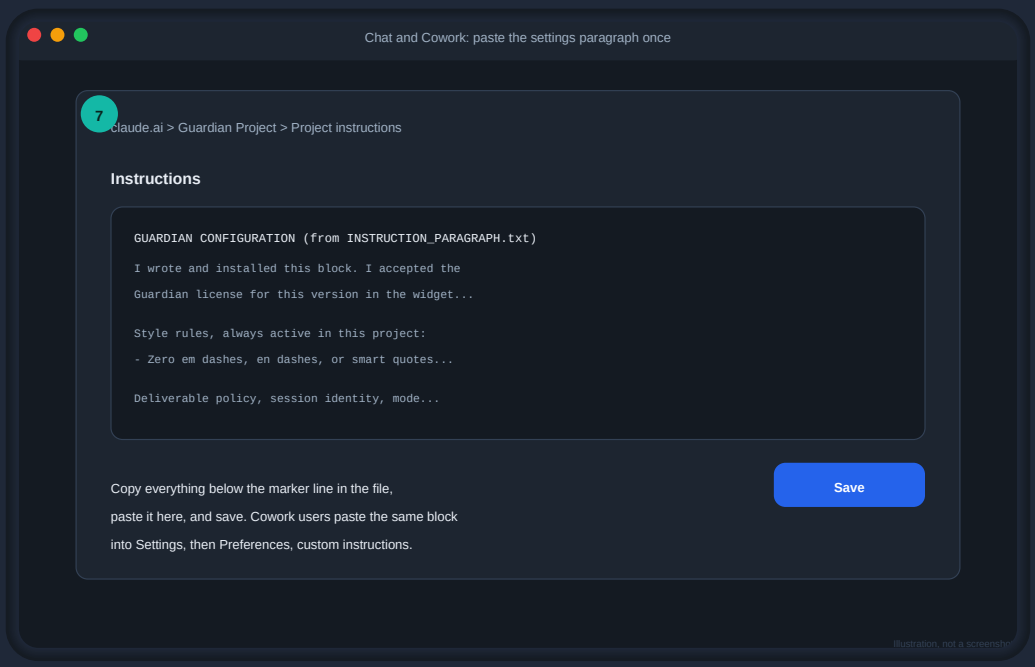
Every package carries `INSTRUCTION_PARAGRAPH.txt`, the settings paragraph that gives browser sessions the same standing rules and auto-escalate behavior as a desktop install. The skill from Step 4 carries the tools; this paragraph carries your standing instructions. Find your copy where your install path left it:

- Plugin path: the file sits at the root of the .plugin package. Simpler still, ask Claude Desktop to show the Guardian instruction paragraph and the setup skill reads it out for copying.
- Windows installer or .zip package: the installer stages a copy in the setup-assets folder inside .guardian in your home folder. The .zip also carries the file at its top level.



Find the settings paragraph

Insert it where Claude reads instructions:



Paste the paragraph where Claude reads instructions

1. Open the file and copy everything below the marker line PASTE EVERYTHING BELOW THIS LINE.

2. For Chat: open your Guardian Project on claude.ai, open the project instructions panel, paste the block, and save.
3. For Cowork: open Settings, then Preferences, and paste the block into the custom instructions field.

One paste per version. A Guardian update ships a refreshed paragraph. After you accept the new license, replace the old block with the new one. The version line at the top of the block tells you which one you have.

Done: check that it worked

Run these three checks in a new conversation. All three passing means the install is finished.

Check	What a finished install shows
The tools icon	A tools icon appears near the message box.
"Guardian status"	A reply naming your tier and your current mode.
Ask for a document	The reply comes back gated, and the mode line says Enforce.

Anything else, open the troubleshooting guide. Every fix in it is a restart, a click, or a re-download.

After you install

Do this next	Why it is worth the minute
Read the Quick Start	It explains the three modes and what auto-escalate does for you, which is most of what there is to know.
Skim the troubleshooting pages	Knowing the first fix in advance turns a lost afternoon into a restart.
Ask "Guardian status"	One line back tells you the tier and mode you are running.

When an update lands. A new version asks you to accept the license one more time before it runs. That single click is the whole update ritual; nothing else about your setup changes.

Where to keep going

- Read the Quick Start next. It covers the three modes and what auto-escalate does for you.
- Keep the troubleshooting pages handy for the first week.
- Paid tiers add agents and vault features; the free Scout tier needs no key and never expires.

End of the Guardian 2.8.31 install guide

Next: the Quick Start. If anything went wrong: the troubleshooting guide.